

How to play poker

A quick guide for **Samantha Fox Strip Poker** (Martech, 1986) and poker in general

Retro Vault
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The idea in one paragraph

Poker is a betting game played with a normal 52-card deck. Everyone puts chips into a shared pot, and whoever holds the best five-card hand at the end – or is the last player who hasn't given up – wins it. Because you can't see the other player's cards, you can also win by **bluffing**: betting as if your hand is strong so your opponent folds a better one.

Hand rankings – best to worst

Only five cards count. Aces are high (and can also be low in the straight A-2-3-4-5). The C64 game shows this same list on its title screen.

	Hand	What it is	Example
1	Straight flush	Five cards in sequence, all the same suit. A-K-Q-J-10 is a <i>royal flush</i> , the best hand there is.	9♠ 8♠ 7♠ 6♠ 5♠
2	Four of a kind	Four cards of the same rank.	Q♠ Q♥ Q♦ Q♣ 4♠
3	Full house	Three of a kind plus a pair.	8♠ 8♦ 8♣ K♥ K♠
4	Flush	Any five cards of the same suit, not in sequence.	A♥ J♥ 9♥ 6♥ 2♥
5	Straight	Five cards in sequence, mixed suits.	10♦ 9♠ 8♥ 7♠ 6♠
6	Three of a kind	Three cards of the same rank.	7♥ 7♠ 7♣ K♦ 2♠
7	Two pair	Two different pairs.	J♠ J♦ 4♠ 4♥ 9♠
8	One pair	Two cards of the same rank.	10♠ 10♥ A♠ 6♦ 3♠
–	High card	None of the above: the highest card plays.	A♦ Q♠ 8♠ 5♥ 3♠

Ties. Same kind of hand? The higher ranks win: a pair of kings beats a pair of nines, an ace-high flush beats a king-high flush. If the main cards are equal, the leftover cards (the *kickers*) decide, highest first. Suits don't rank in normal poker; a truly identical hand splits the pot.

Betting words

- **Ante** – a small forced stake everyone puts in before the cards are dealt, so there's always something to win.
- **Bet** – put chips in when nobody has bet yet this round.
- **Check / Stand** – stay in without betting (only when nobody has bet yet).
- **Call** – match the bet in front of you.
- **Raise** – match the bet *and* add more; now the other player has to call, raise again or fold.
- **Fold** – give up the hand. You lose what you've already put in, but nothing more.

A betting round ends when every player still in has put in the same amount (or everyone checked).

Playing Samantha Fox Strip Poker on the C64

The Commodore 64 version is **five-card draw**, one-on-one against Sam. You both start with **100** credits; the two counters at the bottom left are your stack and Sam's, the box on the right shows the pot (**P**) and the round (**R**).

1. **Ante.** Each of you pays 5 into the pot and you're dealt five cards face up – Sam's stay hidden.
2. **First betting round.** Choose **BET**, **STAND** (check) or **FOLD**. If you bet, pick the amount: **05, 10, 15** or **20**. Sam answers – she may call, raise or fold, and then you get **CALL / RAISE / FOLD**.
3. **The draw.** The bar shows **-1- -2- -3- -4- -5-**, one per card. Pick the cards you want to throw away (they turn face down), then confirm with the arrow at the end to get replacements.
4. **Second betting round**, same choices as before.
5. **Showdown.** The best hand takes the pot. As you take Sam's credits off her she removes an item of clothing; if she wins credits back, she can put things back on.

Controls in the Vault. Move the joystick left/right (arrow keys) to highlight a choice and press fire (**G**) to pick it. Press **Space** at the title screen to start dealing.

The ZX Spectrum and Amstrad versions use seven-card stud instead (see below), with Space to cycle options and Enter to choose.

What to keep in the draw

- **Pair:** keep the pair, swap the other three.
- **Two pair:** keep both, swap one card (about 1 in 12 to make a full house).
- **Three of a kind:** keep them, swap two.
- **Four to a flush or an open-ended straight** (e.g. 8-9-10-J): swap one card and hope – roughly 1 in 5 for the flush, 1 in 6 for the straight.
- **Nothing:** keep your highest card (an ace or king) and swap four. Or bluff.
- How many cards Sam draws is a clue: one card often means two pair or a straight/flush draw; three cards usually means a single pair.

Other poker games in brief

Seven-card stud – each player gets seven cards, some face down and some face up, with a betting round after each new upcard; you make your best five-card hand from the seven. **Texas Hold'em** – today's most popular game: two private cards each plus five shared cards in the middle (the flop, turn and river), four betting rounds, best five out of seven. **Omaha** – like Hold'em, but with four private cards, of which you must use exactly two. The hand rankings above are the same in all of them.

Written for the Retro Vault (retrovault.world) – an overview in our own words, not an official rulebook. For the full rules of every variant, see PokerStars' poker rules: pokerstars.be/en/poker/games/rules. Samantha Fox Strip Poker © 1986 Martech Games / Software Communications.